

IT INDUSTRY

strong passions after job losses. After the y2k boom, when systems were on the verge of a crash, the entire industry was on tenterhooks. Our growth still continued at a healthy rate of 20 to 25 per cent. The secret to this is the fact that we had built enough strength to be independent of external factors.

The emergence of the BPO industry was a landmark in our development and it had many Eureka moments. Be it an American Harvard graduate, Joe Siegelman, who one day sitting in front of his computer, decided to make communication with his secretary just a phone call or a mouse-click away. 'Office Tiger', a software for communication was created in the late 1990s in Chennai and outsourcing came into being as a new concept. We have created such expertise that we have literally become "car mechanics" for the entire IT industry.

When it comes to the Indian IT industry and its evolution, instead of the notion of climbing the ladder, the metaphor of a pyramid seems more apt. If we want to go higher, we must have a stronger and broader base. Our base being so-called "low end" work and the pinnacle being high-end work like R&D and creation of Internet Protocol.

But perhaps there is a justifiable dissatisfaction when we consider the percolation of the IT market. Various factors are attributed to this. For IT to be as widespread as the telecom revolution, there are a lot of things that have to be rectified. The dearth of information in local languages is the main barrier. So is the cost of connectivity, software and hardware which discourages players from expanding their market to the grassroots. We must work towards making the content as compelling as soaps and sports on television, to create an appeal which will make it an important part of every household in India.

It is imperative to understand that IT doesn't mean computers or the Internet, it means more access through community centres, cell phones or land lines. I see the computerisation of the Indian Railways as an example of IT making life easier for the common man. I give credit to N.R. Narayana Murthy as someone who started this revolution by encouraging Indians with no resources and becoming a role model for young entrepreneurs. Also Nasscom's Dewang Mehta, for taking, and talking about IT everywhere.

The IT industry has become a living reality as I look

\$60 bn

is the export target the IT sector has set for 2010. Exports accounted for \$31.4 billion in 2007.

\$16.4 m

was the total size of the Indian technology market (including hardware) in 2007



EARLY START: A family around a computer in '87

back. If a farmer in a far-off village has access to the market prices of vegetables, he will be able to equate his own finances to the market and not be duped by a trader. The information symmetry will correct the market equation as the power of the collective is applied. IT now pervades our lives in many small ways. And for the future I see it as being so ubiquitous that perhaps it won't be something we will talk about anymore. The time we attain that ubiquity, we will be able to change the power equation by empowering people, and giving access to knowledge systems. As they say in the end, knowledge is power, and we hope to deliver it.

as told to Bushra Ahmed

ASHOK SOOTA, president of Wipro, 1987

"I think the computer revolution will come faster into this country than in the West."

The writer is the president of Nasscom